must think about how to do it effectively, to suit everyone's interests, while avoiding exploitation and unfair conduct. This is what the Central and the state governments should decide upon. The Centre alone, or the states alone, cannot solve this problem. But a nation can.'

There was a brief pause in my argument as I stopped to catch my breath. Then the discussion resumed, but I didn't speak any further until the bell rang, indicating that the time was up. Sqn Ldr Virk asked us to remain silent as he scribbled something on a piece of paper. 'All right, girls, all of you spoke well. There's no marking scheme, so I can't tell you how much each of you has scored. I guess the final results will tell you that,' the officer said as he got up with his file. As he left, he looked at me, smiled and said, 'Chest Number 4, you united a divided conversation. Keep it up.'

'Thank you, Sir,' I said and looked at the girls sitting next to me from the corner of my eyes. They whispered something to each other.

As soon as the group dispersed, I hurried towards the PCO booth next to the cafeteria and called up Papaji. 'You once told me to make myself heard when it was required,' I said to him.

'Yes, I remember. What about it?' he asked, to which I replied with a content smile, 'Today, they heard me.'